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History

Harappan Civilisation and Archaeology

Themes in Indian History (Part I) · Theme 1 · Class 12

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Aligned to the latest official syllabus · Concept-first explanations

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Syllabus Alignment

Syllabus Element	Core Concepts Tested by NTA
Early and Mature Harappan	Chronology (c. 2600–1900 BCE), regional cultures, subsistence strategies, botanical and faunal remains.
Agricultural Technologies	Ploughed field at Kalibangan, terracotta plough models at Banawali and Cholistan, canals at Shortughai, reservoirs at Dholavira.
Urban Planning & Architecture	Mohenjodaro layout, Citadel vs Lower Town, brick ratio 1:2:4, Great Bath, warehouse, street grid, covered drainage, courtyard houses.
Craft Production & Trade	Chanhudaro workshop hub, shell work at Nageshwar and Balakot, bead-making materials, drills, procurement from Khetri, South India, Oman, and Mesopotamia.
Seals, Script & Metrology	Steatite seals with animal motifs, pictographic undeciphered script written right-to-left, cubical chert weights in binary and decimal series.
Social Differences & Burials	North-South burials, modest grave goods, copper mirrors, utilitarian vs luxury goods (faience pots).
Religious Interpretations	Mother Goddess figurines, Priest-King sculpture, Proto-Shiva yogi seal, conical stone lingas, fire altars at Kalibangan and Lothal.
Decline & Historiography	Disintegration theories, Cunningham's confusion, Marshall's horizontal excavation, Wheeler's stratigraphy, and post-1947 Indian discoveries.

CUET EXAM STRATEGY & SCORING TIPS

CUET Scoring Tip: NTA frequently sets chronological matching questions pairing archaeological pioneers with their exact methodological breakthroughs: Cunningham (1875, missed antiquity), Daya Ram Sahni (1921, Harappa seals), Rakhal Das Banerji (1922, Mohenjodaro), John Marshall (1924, world announcement, horizontal digs), and Mortimer Wheeler (1944, stratigraphy). Master the geographical distribution of raw materials: lapis lazuli was procured strictly from **Shortughai** in Afghanistan, carnelian from **Bharuch**, copper from **Khetri** and **Oman**, and steatite from **Rajasthan/north Gujarat**.

1. Beginnings and Chronological Framework

The Indus Valley or Harappan Civilisation is dated between **c. 2600 and 1900 BCE** for its mature phase. Archaeologists divide the regional cultural sequence into three distinct chronological horizons:

- **Early Harappan (c. 3000–2600 BCE):** Marked by distinct pottery styles, small villages, and limited craft production. There were no large cities. Pastoralism and small-scale farming sustained the communities.
- **Mature Harappan (c. 2600–1900 BCE):** The fully urban phase. Cities exhibited monumental brick architecture, uniform weights and measures, elaborate drainage networks, and specialized craft production.
- **Late Harappan (Post-1900 BCE):** Period of urban breakdown. Standardized artifacts vanished. Populations migrated eastward into Gujarat, Haryana, and western Uttar Pradesh.

The civilization is named after **Harappa**, the first site discovered in 1921. Its distinctive cultural markers include steatite seals, baked bricks, chert blades, and stone beads. Settlements stretched from **Sutkagen Dor** in Baluchistan to **Alamgirpur** in Uttar Pradesh, and from **Manda** in Jammu down to **Daimabad** in Maharashtra.

2. Subsistence Strategies & Agricultural Technology

Harappans lived on a wide range of domesticated plant and animal products. Archaeologists reconstruct diet through archaeobotanical seeds and zooarchaeological animal bones.

Plant Remains and Diets

- **Grains Found:** Grains included wheat, barley, lentil, chickpea, and sesame.
- **Millets:** Millet seeds are excavated predominantly from sites in **Gujarat**.
- **Rice Remains:** Finding rice grains was comparatively **rare** in mature sites.
- **Food Processing:** Saddle querns made of hard igneous rock or sandstone were used for grinding grain. Pounding querns had a cavity scooped out for spices.

Animal Remains

- **Domestic Animals:** Bones of cattle, sheep, goat, buffalo, and pig indicate domestication.
- **Wild Species:** Bones of boar, deer, and gharial prove Harappans hunted or obtained meat from hunter communities.
- **Fish and Fowl:** Fish bones and bird remains are abundant along riverine and coastal outposts.

Agricultural Tools and Water Management

Agriculture required sophisticated irrigation in semi-arid environments:

- **Plough Evidence:** A ploughed field showing two intersecting sets of furrows at right angles was discovered at **Kalibangan** in Rajasthan. This proves two different crops were grown together.
- **Terracotta Plough Models:** Clay models of ploughs have been unearthed at **Cholistan** and **Banawali** (Haryana).
- **Canal Traces:** Remnants of irrigation canals were found at **Shortughai** in northern Afghanistan, but not in Punjab or Sindh.
- **Water Storage:** Stone-cut **reservoirs** were discovered at **Dholavira** in Gujarat, used to harvest rainwater for agriculture and municipal use.

3. Mohenjodaro: A Planned Urban Centre

Mohenjodaro is the most celebrated Harappan city, illustrating masterful spatial planning. The settlement was deliberately partitioned into two distinct physical sectors:

The Citadel (Upper Settlement)

- **Position and Base:** Located on the western side. It was smaller in physical area but elevated on giant mud-brick platforms.
- **Walled Enclosure:** The Citadel was surrounded by brick defensive walls, separating it physically from the Lower Town.
- **Public Purpose:** It hosted monumental structures reserved for public rituals, state administration, and civic gatherings.
- **The Great Bath:** A vast rectangular tank set inside an open courtyard. It was made watertight using tightly fitted fired bricks laid on edge and sealed with **gypsum mortar**. Two flights of steps led down into the basin from the north and south. It was flanked by rooms on three sides, with one room housing a large brick well.
- **The Warehouse / Granary:** A massive brick foundation whose upper wooden superstructure decayed. It served as a centralized storage facility for state grain reserves.

The Lower Town (Residential Sector)

- **Vast Residential Area:** Positioned to the east. It was larger, lower, and divided into neat residential blocks.
- **Walled Perimeters:** The Lower Town was also enclosed by outer brick walls.
- **Uniform Bricks:** All architectural construction used standardized bricks with a strict dimensional ratio of **1 : 2 : 4** (thickness : width : length). This uniform ratio was maintained across all Harappan territories.

Street Grid and Municipal Drainage

- **Gridiron Pattern:** Roads and streets were laid out along an approximate **grid**, intersecting at **90-degree right angles**.
- **Streets First:** Streets and drainage ditches were laid out first, after which domestic houses were constructed along the grid.
- **Covered Channels:** Street drains were constructed of kiln-fired bricks or dressed limestone slabs. Slabs could be lifted for periodic desilting.
- **Soak Pits and Traps:** Domestic waste water passed through settling sumps where heavy solids settled, letting clear wastewater spill into street sewers.
- **Sanitary Standard:** The drainage system remains one of the most complete ancient sanitary works in human history.

Domestic Architecture and Privacy

- **Courtyard Focus:** Domestic houses centered on an open courtyard. Rooms were arranged around its four edges.
- **Climatic Hub:** The courtyard served as the family centre for cooking and weaving during hot seasons.

- **Privacy Culture:** Ground-level exterior walls had **no windows**. The main entrance did not allow a direct line of sight into the interior courtyard.
- **Bathrooms & Wells:** Every house possessed an individual brick-paved bathroom. Drains connected directly through the wall into street channels. Mohenjodaro alone possessed approximately **700 brick wells**.

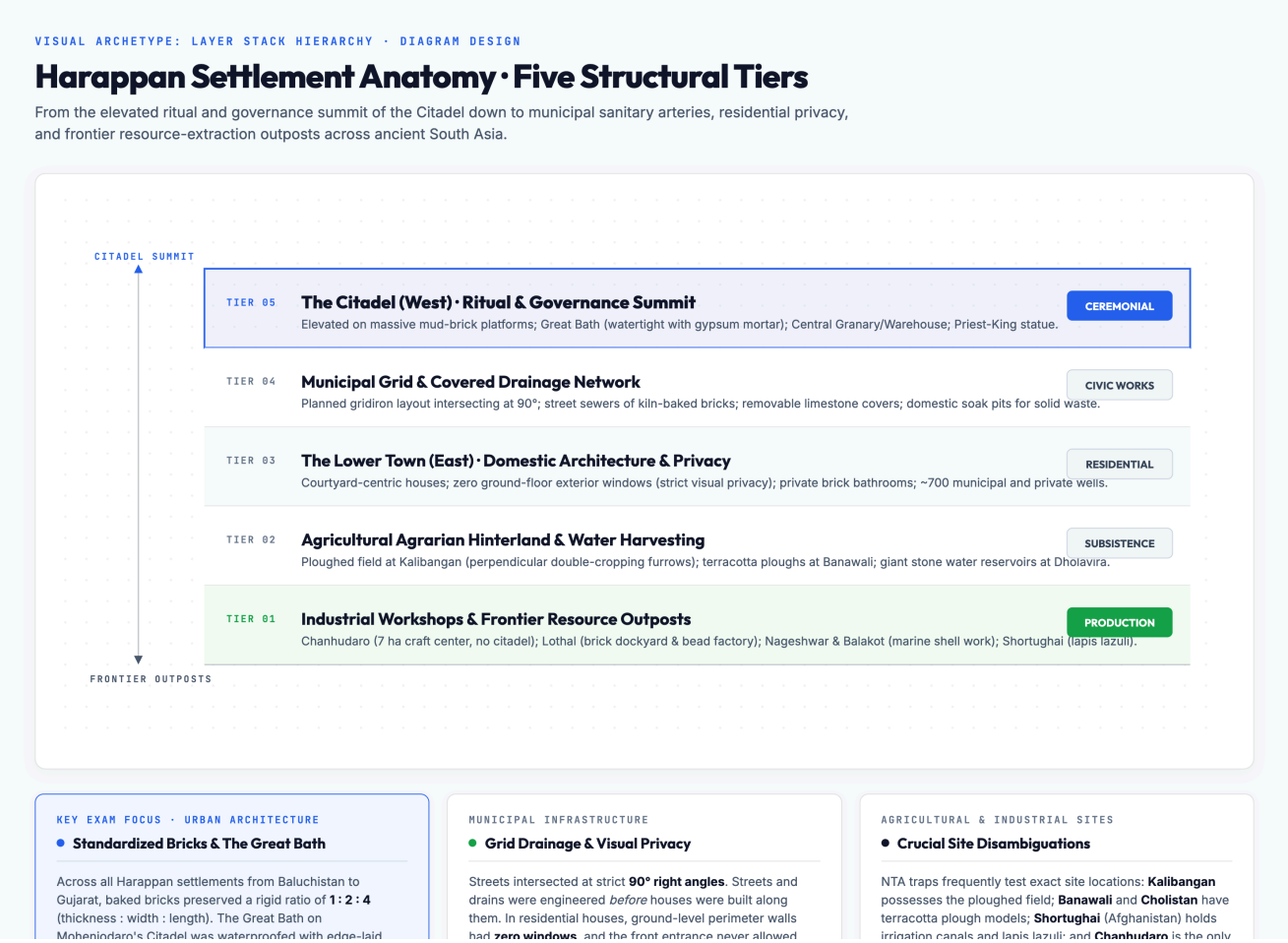


Figure 1: Harappan Urban Anatomy, Domestic Architecture & Settlement Hierarchy

4. Specialized Craft Production and Raw Material Procurement

Craft production formed the economic engine of Harappan urban life.

Specialised Craft Centers

- **Chanhudaro:** A tiny settlement of less than 7 hectares, almost entirely devoted to craft production. Crafts included bead-making, seal-cutting, shell-working, and weight-manufacturing.
- **Coastal Shell Centers: Nageshwar** and **Balakot** were coastal settlements situated near natural molluscan colonies. They specialized in manufacturing shell bangles, ladles, and inlays.
- **Lothal:** A manufacturing hub in Gujarat. Excavations revealed a large bead factory, drill tools, and an expansive brick dockyard basin.

Craft Materials and Technology

- **Stones:** Carnelian (a beautiful red stone), jasper, crystal, quartz, and **steatite**.
- **Metals:** Copper, bronze, and gold.
- **Other Media:** Terracotta, shell, and **faience** (a manufactured paste of crushed quartz and gum, glazed and fired into glossy pots).
- **Bead Techniques:** Harappans shaped beads into discs, cylinders, barrels, and spheres. Steatite micro-beads were made by moulding steatite powder paste. Carnelian got its deep red colour from firing yellowish raw pebbles. Specialized drill bits were recovered at Chanhudaro, Lothal, and Dholavira.

Procurement Strategies and External Trade

Harappans secured distant raw materials through multiple channels:

Raw Material	Source Region	Procurement Method / Mechanism
Copper	Khetri (Rajasthan) & Oman (Magan)	Expeditions sent to Ganeshwar-Jodhpura culture; maritime voyages across the Arabian Sea.
Lapis Lazuli	Shortughai (Badakhshan, Afghanistan)	Specialized frontier trade outpost located directly beside mines.
Carnelian	Bharuch & Lothal (Gujarat)	Regional barter and coastal transit from Narmada basin.
Steatite	South Rajasthan & North Gujarat	Short-distance transport of soft soapstone blocks.
Gold	Kolar (South India)	Organized long-distance expeditions to southern riverine regions.
Shell	Nageshwar & Balakot	Direct coastal harvesting from the Arabian Sea.

Chemical analysis proves that Harappan copper and Omani metal artifacts both share characteristic traces of **nickel**, proving trade contact. Mesopotamian cuneiform texts of the third millennium BCE record maritime trade with three overseas lands:

- **Dilmun:** Identified with the island of Bahrain in the Persian Gulf.
- **Magan:** Identified with the peninsula of Oman.
- **Meluhha:** Identified as the land of seafarers, meaning the Harappan civilization.

Mesopotamian texts describe Meluhha as a source of carnelian, lapis lazuli, copper, gold, and timber. Harappan seals, weights, dice, and carnelian beads have been excavated across Mesopotamian cities including Ur, Kish, and Susa.

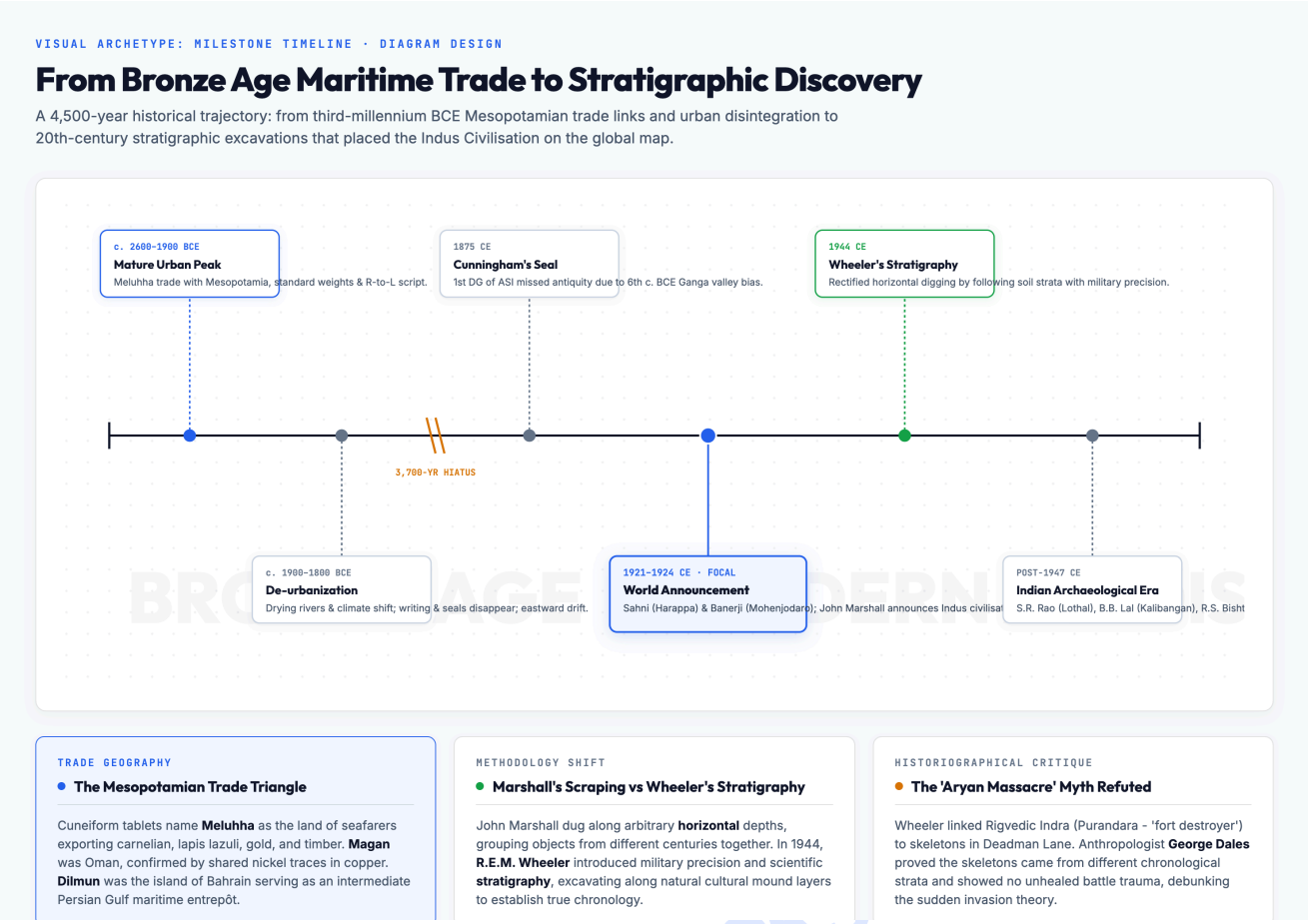


Figure 2: Harappan Economic Exchange, Sealing Systems & Historiographical Discoveries

5. Seals, Script, and Weights

Seals, writing, and standardized measurement ensured trust across thousands of miles.

Steatite Seals and Sealing Technology

- **Material and Shape:** Seals were cut from soft steatite stone into squares or rectangles.
- **Motifs:** They featured animal engravings, most notably the **unicorn**, humped bull, tiger, and elephant.
- **Function of Sealings:** Wet clay tags (**sealings**) were pressed over tied rope knots on merchandise sacks. If a parcel reached its destination with its clay impression unbroken, it proved the shipment was uncompromised.

The Undeciphered Harappan Script

- **Number of Signs:** The script contains between **375 and 400 distinct signs**.
- **Direction of Writing:** It was written from **right to left**. On seals, signs are comfortably spaced on the right but compressed and cramped on the left edge.
- **Non-Alphabetic:** Because the signs are numerous, the script was clearly pictographic or logo-syllabic, not alphabetic.
- **Longest Inscription:** The longest single continuous inscription contains only **26 signs**.
- **Widespread Media:** Writing appeared on seals, copper tools, rims of jars, bone rods, and a monumental wooden signboard at Dholavira.

Metrology and Chert Weights

- **Material:** Weights were cut from **chert** stone into exact cubes with no markings.
- **Denomination System:** Lower denominations followed a **binary** progression: $1, 2, 4, 8, 16, 32$ up to $12,800$.
- **Decimal Upper Tier:** Higher denominations followed the **decimal system**.
- **Precision Scales:** Smaller weights were made for measuring precious metals and beads. Small copper scale pans have been unearthed.

6. Ancient Authority, Social Differences & Burials

Did the Harappan civilization have centralized kings or an egalitarian society?

Clues to Social Stratification

- **Burials:** Dead were laid in pits, usually aligned **North to South**. Some graves were lined with fired bricks.
- **Grave Goods:** Pots, shell ornaments, beads, and rare **copper mirrors** accompanied the dead.
- **No Massive Treasure:** Unlike Egyptian royal tombs, Harappans did not bury immense wealth with their dead. They believed in an afterlife, but prioritized modest utility.
- **Utilitarian vs Luxury Artifacts:** Daily stone querns, needles, and pottery are found everywhere. In contrast, rare luxury objects like delicate miniature pots of **faience** are found concentrated exclusively in large cities like Mohenjodaro and Harappa, never in tiny villages.

The Question of Central Authority

Archaeologists debate the nature of Harappan political authority:

- **Single Ruler Theory:** The astonishing uniformity of pottery, brick ratios, urban drainage, and planned settlement layouts suggests a single centralized state.
- **Priest-King Sculpture:** A seated stone statue unearthed at Mohenjodaro shows a bearded figure wearing an embroidered robe with a trefoil motif. Scholars drew analogies with Mesopotamian priest-kings, though no confirmed palace or temple has ever been identified.
- **Multiple Rulers Hypothesis:** Other scholars argue Mohenjodaro, Harappa, and Dholavira each had separate rulers representing city-states.
- **Collective Governance:** Some argue there were no absolute kings, and civic decisions were steered by merchant guilds or collective civic assemblies.

7. Religious Beliefs and Problems of Interpretation

Because the script remains undeciphered, religious beliefs are reconstructed through material analogies with later Hinduism:

- **The "Mother Goddess":** Terracotta figurines of heavily ornamented women wearing fan-shaped headdresses were classified as mother goddesses.

- **The "Proto-Shiva" Seal:** A yogic figure seated cross-legged on a low stool surrounded by an elephant, tiger, rhinoceros, water buffalo, and two deer beneath the seat. John Marshall identified this as a precursor to the Hindu deity Shiva (**Pashupati**). However, the Vedic text Rigveda describes Rudra neither as Pashupati nor as a yogi.
- **Linga Stones:** Numerous smooth conical stone objects have been classified as **lingas** associated with phallic worship.
- **Fire Altars:** Brick enclosures with charcoal and ash, identified as ritual **fire altars**, were unearthed at **Kalibangan** and **Lothal**.
- **Sacred Trees & Animals:** Pipal leaf motifs and the one-horned mythical unicorn engraved on seals indicate tree and animal veneration.

8. Decline of the Civilisation & Archaeological Discoveries

The Fall: What Caused the Collapse?

By **c. 1800 BCE**, mature Harappan urban life disintegrated across Sindh and Punjab:

- **Environmental Pressures:** Deforestation to fuel brick kilns, recurrent tectonic shifts, changing river courses, and the drying up of the Saraswati river system triggered agricultural collapse.
- **Disappearance of Distinctive Markers:** Standardized weights, writing, seals, and monumental brick structures disappeared.
- **Debunking the "Aryan Massacre":** Mortimer Wheeler famously claimed the Rigvedic god **Indra** destroyed Harappan cities, pointing to unburied skeletons in Deadman Lane at Mohenjodaro. Anthropologist **George Dales** later disproved this theory by demonstrating the skeletons belonged to different stratigraphic layers and showed no unhealed battle trauma.

Archaeological Historiography: Key Pioneers

Archaeologist	Period / Year	Key Contribution & Methodological Impact
Alexander Cunningham	1875	First Director-General of ASI ("Father of Indian Archaeology"). Missed the true antiquity of a Harappan seal because he believed Indian urbanization began in the 6th century BCE Ganga valley.
Daya Ram Sahni	1921	Discovered the first ancient seals at Harappa in Montgomery district, West Punjab.
Rakhal Das Banerji	1922	Found identical seals at Mohenjodaro in Larkana district, Sindh, proving a shared culture.
John Marshall	1924	Director-General of ASI who formally announced the discovery of the Indus Civilisa-

		tion to the world. He excavated horizontally along arbitrary levels, which mixed artifacts from different stratigraphic layers.
R.E.M. Wheeler	1944	Director-General who introduced military precision and scientific **stratigraphy**, excavating strictly along mound layers rather than arbitrary horizontal lines.
Post-1947 Explorers	1950s–1990s	S.R. Rao excavated Lothal dockyard; B.B. Lal and B.K. Thapar excavated Kalibangan; R.S. Bisht uncovered Dholavira and Banawali.

Key Facts & Terms: One-Stop Revision

- **Citadel:** Elevated western fortification of Harappan settlements housing public monuments.
- **Lower Town:** Eastern residential quarter planned on a strict gridiron pattern.
- **Steatite:** Soft talc stone used to manufacture seals, beads, and the Priest-King statue.
- **Chert:** Microcrystalline quartz used for manufacturing uniform cubical balance weights and blades.
- **Carnelian:** Red gemstone obtained from Gujarat, drilled with specialized bronze bits.
- **Lapis Lazuli:** Deep blue stone prized by elites, procured exclusively from Shortughai.
- **Faience:** Costly artificial vitreous material made of sintered quartz, used for luxury perfume vessels.
- **Meluhha:** Mesopotamian cuneiform name for the Indus region ("land of seafarers").
- **Pashupati:** The horned yogic deity depicted on the famous Proto-Shiva seal.
- **Stratigraphy:** Geological and archaeological study of earth layers to establish relative dating.

10 High-Yield CUET Practice Questions

Q1. A ploughed field with two perpendicular sets of furrows indicating double cropping was excavated at which Harappan site?

(A) Banawali
(B) Kalibangan
(C) Dholavira
(D) Shortughai

Q2. Which of the following raw materials was obtained by the Harappans from Shortughai in Badakhshan, Afghanistan?

(A) Carnelian
(B) Copper
(C) Lapis lazuli
(D) Steatite

Q3. What was the standardized dimensional ratio of baked bricks used across mature Harappan cities?

(A) 1 : 2 : 3
(B) 1 : 2 : 4
(C) 1 : 3 : 5
(D) 2 : 3 : 4

Q4. Which tiny Harappan settlement (less than 7 hectares) was almost exclusively devoted to craft production such as bead-making, seal-cutting, and shell-working?

(A) Mohenjodaro
(B) Harappa
(C) Chanhudaro
(D) Kalibangan

Q5. In ancient Mesopotamian texts, which geographic name was used to designate the Harappan region, referred to as the 'land of seafarers'?

(A) Magan
(B) Dilmun
(C) Meluhha
(D) Ur

Q6. Lower denominations of Harappan chert weights followed which mathematical system?

(A) Decimal system
(B) Duodecimal system
(C) Binary system
(D) Sexagesimal system

Q7. Why did Alexander Cunningham, the first Director-General of the ASI, fail to recognize the antiquity of the Harappan seal given to him?

(A) He assumed the seal was a modern forgery.
(B) He believed Indian civilization began with the 6th century BCE cities in the Ganga valley.
(C) He could not read the Brahmi script.
(D) The seal was too weathered to inspect.

Q8. What critical methodological flaw characterized John Marshall's excavations at Mohenjodaro, later rectified by R.E.M. Wheeler?

(A) He failed to use photography during digs.
(B) He excavated horizontally along regular levels, ignoring natural mound stratigraphy.
(C) He only used local laborers without supervisors.
(D) He refused to publish field reports.

Q9. At which Harappan sites have brick structures identified as 'fire altars' been discovered?

(A) Mohenjodaro and Harappa
(B) Kalibangan and Lothal
(C) Dholavira and Chanhudaro
(D) Shortughai and Balakot

Q10. Which scholar disproved Mortimer Wheeler's hypothesis of an 'Aryan massacre' at Mohenjodaro by proving that the skeletons lacked unhealed battle trauma?

(A) John Marshall
(B) Daya Ram Sahni
(C) George Dales
(D) Alexander Cunningham

Step-by-Step Solutions

Sol. Q1. A ploughed field dating to early Harappan levels was discovered at **Kalibangan** in Rajasthan. It featured two sets of furrows cutting at right angles, showing that two different crops were cultivated together. Terracotta plough models were found at Banawali and Cholistan, not the ploughed field.

Answer: (B)

Sol. Q2. **Shortughai** in northern Afghanistan was established directly near the prized quarries of deep blue **lapis lazuli**. Carnelian came from Bharuch, copper from Khetri and Oman, and steatite from Rajasthan.

Answer: (C)

Sol. Q3. Harappan baked bricks possessed a strictly standardized ratio where thickness was 1 unit, width was twice the thickness (2 units), and length was four times the thickness (4 units), giving a ratio of **1 : 2 : 4**.

Answer: (B)

Sol. Q4. **Chanhudaro** was a tiny industrial site of under 7 hectares completely dedicated to specialized craft manufacturing including bead drilling, shell cutting, seal engraving, and weight fabrication. It is also famous for having no fortified citadel.

Answer: (C)

Sol. Q5. Cuneiform tablets from Mesopotamia describe **Meluhha** as the land of seafarers from which they imported carnelian, lapis lazuli, gold, and copper. Magan was Oman, and Dilmun was Bahrain.

Answer: (C)

Sol. Q6. Lower denominations of Harappan cubical chert weights were strictly **binary** $(1, 2, 4, 8, 16, 32$ up to $12,800)$, whereas higher denominations operated on the decimal system.

Answer: (C)

Sol. Q7. Cunningham relied heavily on 7th century CE Chinese pilgrim accounts (Xuanzang) and held the firm preconception that Indian urbanization originated in the **Ganga valley** around the 6th century BCE, thereby misdating the Harappan seal.

Answer: (B)

Sol. Q8. Marshall excavated **horizontally** across units of uniform measured depth. As a result, artifacts belonging to different historical strata were grouped together, obscuring archaeological chronology. Wheeler introduced scientific **stratigraphy** in 1944.

Answer: (B)

Sol. Q9. Brick structures classified by archaeologists as **fire altars** used for ritual oblations were unearthed at **Kalibangan** (Rajasthan) and **Lothal** (Gujarat).

Answer: (B)

Sol. Q10. In 1964, archaeologist **George Dales** published a systematic critique showing that the skeletons in Deadman Lane at Mohenjodaro were buried at different stratigraphic depths and showed no signs of violent slaughter or unhealed blade trauma, disproving Wheeler's invasion myth.

Answer: (C)

Wrong-Answer Clinic

Common Student Mistake	Why Candidates Pick It	The Accurate CUET Rule
Confusing Banawali and Kalibangan	Both are northern sites related to farming.	The **ploughed field** is at Kalibangan (Rajasthan). Terracotta **plough models** are at Banawali (Haryana).
Assuming Harappans buried gold hordes	Believing ancient civilisations buried treasure like Egyptian pyramids.	Harappan burials contained modest pottery, shell bangles, and copper mirrors. They avoided burying heavy gold in graves.
Assuming Harappan script was written Left-to-Right	Assuming ancient scripts match modern Devanagari or English.	The Harappan script was written **Right-to-Left**. Words are spacious on the right but compressed on the left edge.
Confusing Meluhha with Magan	Both are foreign regions mentioned in Mesopotamian texts.	**Meluhha** is the Harappan land ("land of seafarers"). **Magan** is Oman, proven by nickel traces in copper artifacts.
Attributing stratigraphy to Marshall	Marshall is famous for announcing the discovery in 1924.	Marshall excavated **horizontally**, ignoring stratigraphy. **R.E.M. Wheeler** introduced stratigraphy in 1944.